



Apex Life 26

SP Football Life 2026
Modlist & Manager's Guide

Version 2.2 — 2026

Table of Contents

Contents

Table of Contents	2
Installation & Mod Stack	4
Base Game Installation	4
Layer 2 — Audio Framework & Atmosphere	7
Layer 3 — Visual Foundation	8
Layer 4 — Faces	9
Layer 5 — Stadiums	9
Layer 6 — Graphics Overhaul	11
Layer 7 — Camera	14
Layer 8 — Balls	15
Layer 9 — Gameplay	16
Layer 10 — Career Depth	19
Layer 11 — Optional Leagues	21
Layer 12 — Sleeve Patch & Armband Server	22
Layer 13 — Soundtrack Server	22
Layer 14 — Kitpacks	23
Layer 15 — Accessories	23
Layer 16 — Scoreboards & TV Logos	24
Layer 17 — Stadium Additions	24
Layer 18 — Kits & Adboards	26
Layer 19 — Audio Additions	28
Layer 20 — Immersion & Visuals	29
Known Limitations	30
Save Compatibility Warning	30
Sider Configuration	31
How Sider Works	31
The sider.ini File	31
+ [lua] — Module Registration	31
+ [cpk] — Live CPK Roots	33
Common Pitfalls	34
Backup Strategy	35
Manager's Dossier	36
Before You Start	36
Controls Primer	36
Tactics System	38
Scouting & Youth Academy	39
Transfer Market	41
Training & Development	42
Match-Day Management	44
Manager Personas	47

The Disgraced Legend	47
The Data Unicorn	47
The Basque Purist	48
The Journeyman	49
Self-Imposed Rule Frameworks	50

Installation & Mod Stack

Read this first — Sider IS your mod manager. There is no Nexus-style manager for FL26, and none is recommended: no third-party tool understands this stack's three load-bearing mechanisms — `map_teams.txt` merging, `cpk.root` priority (later entries win), and library-module load order (`nesalib/CommonLib` before the modules that need them). Sider itself does the managing (live CPK overlay + Lua modules); the layers below ARE the install order. Install in order, verify the gated layers before continuing, and keep the Sider Configuration chapter open beside this one — it holds the master `sider.ini` template that mirrors every layer's snippets.

If you skip a layer: some later steps become mandatory instead of optional. Do not skip silently — use this table:

If you skip	Then you must
Layer 3 (Essentials)	Install SoundServer (Layer 2), Ball Server (Layer 8), and Gameplay Loader (Layer 9) standalone — each row says how.
Layer 5 (Stadiums)	Layer 17 map merges have no base — configure <code>map_teams.txt</code> from scratch.
Layer 10 UML	Layer 16 scoreboards become your WC2026 coverage — UML's exclusive boards won't be there.
Layers 11, 19, 20	Nothing — these are optional by design. Skip freely.

Table 1: Skip-layer consequences

Sync rule: each layer's snippet is authoritative. The master template in the Sider Configuration chapter mirrors them; any divergence is a bug — report it against the layer, and the fix lands in both places (logged in STATUS.md).

Base Game Installation

Download SP Football Life 2026 from caocacao.net at caocacao.net. The base game (v1.0) is an 11-part archive available via Mediafire and Sharemods mirrors. Extract all parts, then run `SPFL26_setup.exe` to install. The game ships as a standalone installer — no PES 2021 purchase or installation is required. 36 pre-installed stadiums are included in the base installation. English Commentary v8 (Peter Drury & Jim Beglin) is available as a separate download on the same page.

Component	Version	Installation
SP Football Life 2026 (base)	v1.0	Download the 11-part archive from caocacao.net (Mediafire + Sharemods mirrors). Extract all parts, then run SPFL26_setup.exe. Choose a clean, unprotected directory — never install over another game.
Update v2.0	v2.0	Download from caocacao.net (Modsfire + Sharemods). Major database update: 15 new promoted teams, winter transfers, refreshed player stats, and gameplay adjustments (slower, more tactical pacing, revised set-piece power). Extract and run the installer over your existing FL26 install. Compatible with all prior save games.
Update v2.1	v2.1	Download from caocacao.net . Database and kit update. Apply after v2.0.
Update v2.2 (final)	May 12 2026	Download from pes-files.com (Modsfire mirror + official link page). Final post-season update: database fixes (national teams), club + national kits. Requires v2.0 installed. Career saves from any FL26 version continue. Ships a new edit file. Unzip, run the installer, select the game directory.
v2.20 Option File	Jun 2026	Download from caocacao.net . World Cup 2026 rosters and confirmed summer transfers through June 25, 2026. Backup your EDIT00000000 file first, then install over your existing FL26 installation and replace files when prompted. Compatible with FL26 v2.20.
Gondowan Final EDIT File	Sep 2026 (final)	Download from the r/SPFootballLife release post . Summer window to Sep 14 2026, 800+ rating revisions, overalls/positions/heights. Supersedes the Jun 2026 v2.20 Option File above. Backup EDIT00000000 first — this overwrites Edit Mode customs. Not compatible with UML or private patches.

Table 2: Base Game Components

Installation path: Avoid C:\Program Files and C:\Program Files (x86). Windows UAC virtualization interferes with Sider module loading, livecpk path resolution, and runtime asset injection. Use a short root path — for example, D:\FL26 or C:\Games\FL26.

System Requirements: Defaults to medium quality; adjustable in the game's video settings menu.

Tier	Spec	Detail
Minimum	OS	Windows 7 SP1 / 8.1 / 10 (64-bit)
	CPU	Intel Core i5-3470 / AMD FX 4350
	RAM	10 GB
	GPU	NVIDIA GTX 670 / AMD Radeon HD 7870
	VRAM	2 GB
	DirectX	11.0
	Storage	40 GB free
	Resolution	1280 x 720
Recommended	OS	Windows 11 (64-bit)
	CPU	Intel Core i7-9700 / AMD Ryzen 7 3700X
	RAM	10 GB
	GPU	NVIDIA GTX 980 / AMD Radeon R9 390X
	VRAM	6 GB (10 GB for 4K)
	DirectX	11.0
	Storage	40 GB free
	Resolution	1920 x 1080

Table 3: System Requirements

Verification: After installation, launch `FL_2026_start.exe` once. Confirm the game boots to the main menu. This generates configuration files, initializes the save directory in `Documents\KONAMI\`, and confirms your system meets the runtime requirements. Exit before installing mods.

Directory Anatomy: The `FL26` root contains these directories relevant to the mod stack:

- `Sider\` — Sider Lua modules. Copy each `.lua` module here and enable it in `sider.ini`.
- `livecpk\` — Live CPK root. Mods placed in subdirectories here are loaded at runtime via `cpk.root` entries.
- `content\` — Structured content root for stadiums, faces, and large asset packs.
- `SiderAddons\` — Some community mod bundles unpack content here; merge with existing directories when prompted.
- `sider.ini` — Core configuration file controlling module loading (`lua.module`), CPK roots (`cpk.root`), and startup behavior. Covered in detail in the Sider Configuration chapter.

Launch order: Launch the game through `FL_2026_start.exe`. This is the launcher that initializes Sider and injects all mod content before handing off to the game engine. The desktop shortcut created during installation also points to this executable. Never launch the game executable directly.

Layer 2 — Audio Framework & Atmosphere

Mod	Details	Install
SoundServer	Audio mixing framework by nesa24 (JUCE-based). Controls crowd volume, referee calls, announcer levels, and ambient stadium atmosphere independently. Bundled in the Essentials Mod Pack (Layer 3). Standalone: PESNewupdate mirror (nesa24/Digitalfoxx, Sider 7) or EvoWeb — search: “SoundServer nesa24”.	Place the SoundServer Lua module in Sider\livecpk\mods\lua. Enable in sider.ini with lua.module = "SoundServer.lua". Configure levels in-game via the Sider overlay. If you installed the Essentials Mod Pack first, skip this step — the module is already present.
Predator002 Chant Pack V8	Thousands of team-specific chants plus Chants-Base ambient crowd audio. Player-specific chants included. V8 / V8.1 confirmed active August 2026. Download: pes-files.ru — V8.1 AIO or EvoWeb — search: “Predator002 chants”.	Extract to livecpk\preds-root\. Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\preds-root" to your sider.ini.
Referee Whistle Mod (SoulBallZ)	High-fidelity whistle replacements — 7 options (Default, A–F), 300–400% volume variants. Download: caocacao.net — Sider + CPK versions (Modsfire/Sharemods) .	Pick one variant, copy its Referee Whistle Fix folder to livecpk\mods. Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\Referee Whistle Fix" to sider.ini.
Atmosphere / Stadium Sound Overhaul	Goal reactions, jeers, momentum crowd swells, and dynamic stadium ambience. No single canonical file — community packs via EvoWeb — search: “atmosphere sound overhaul”. SoundServer (above) + Predator002 cover the baseline if you skip this.	Extract to a subdirectory under livecpk\mods (e.g. livecpk\atmosphere-overhaul\). Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\atmosphere-overhaul" to sider.ini.

Table 4: Layer 2 — Audio Framework & Atmosphere

Volume tuning: In-game, set Commentary to 10–12 in the audio settings. Balance Stadium Sound against Commentary to preference — the Atmosphere Overhaul and Predator002 packs drive the

stadium mix, so keep crowd channels high. Use SoundServer’s Sider overlay for fine-grained per-channel adjustment.

Layer 3 — Visual Foundation

Mod	Details	Install
Essentials Mod Pack (SPFL 26)	Community-curated all-in-one bundle — the recommended visual and systems foundation for this mod stack. Bundles: Ball Server (Ballpack v60 AIO by Hawke), SoundServer (nesa24/juce), Gameplay Loader with multiple gameplay options, scoreboards, adboards, updated kits/boots/gloves, referee kits by RezvFX, and entrance scenes. v1.4; confirmed active August 2026. Direct thread: EvoWeb thread 103385 .	Extract the archive into your FL26 root directory. When prompted, merge SiderAddons\ with the existing folder — this populates livecpk roots and Sider modules. The pack includes pre-configured cpk.root entries; verify they appear in your sider.ini. Several mods listed in Layers 2, 8, and 9 (SoundServer, Ball Server, Gameplay Loader) are included in this pack — install Layer 3 first, then skip the standalone downloads for bundled modules.

Table 5: Layer 3 — Visual Foundation

This pack is the recommended visual baseline. It installs several community standards (ball server, kit server, scoreboard selector) that later layers expect to be present. Do not skip this layer.

Verify before continuing: launch via FL_2026 start.exe, press Spacebar for the Sider overlay — expect SoundServer, BallServer, and GameplayLoader listed as loaded. If any is missing, check its lua.module line exists in sider.ini and the .lua file is in Sider\ (see Missing-module pitfall). Do not continue until all three load.

Layer 4 — Faces

Mod	Details	Install
Mega Facepack V5 (Football4Life)	Primary recommendation. 17,555 faces across 5 parts. V5 is a complete stand-alone package — no previous versions required. Available at pesoccerworld.com .	Download all 5 parts, extract from the first archive with WinRAR, and copy the extracted download folder contents to SP Football Life 26\download\. Allocate 40+ GB free space for extraction.
Managers Facepack V1	Supplementary. Manager faces for Master League. Available at pesoccerworld.com .	Install after the main facepack. Copy to SP Football Life 26\download\.
Youngster Facepack	Supplementary. 122 young player faces. Available at pesoccerworld.com .	Install after the main facepack. Copy to SP Football Life 26\download\.
Special Facepack (Halobaim)	Supplementary. Additional special faces curated by Halobaim. Available at pesoccerworld.com .	Install after the main facepack. Copy to SP Football Life 26\download\.
SmokePatch Real Faces Update 4	Official cumulative update: +600 faces in Update 4 (12 May 2026; 1,400 across U1–U4, includes all previous). 8 pre-installed cpk (1–6 main, 7 updates, 8 next season); 15k+ faces; 37.4 GB disk (34.5 GB archives) — raise pagefile. ID-safe alternative/supplement to Mega Facepack V5. Compat: SP FL26 (older versions = mismatched IDs). Available at pessmokepatch.com .	Extract 01_smkdb_fa7.cpk and replace the older file in SP Football Life 26\download\.

Table 6: Layer 4 — Faces

Recommendation: Install Mega Facepack V5 (17,555 faces, 5 parts) — it is a complete standalone package requiring no prior version. Add the three supplementary packs (Managers, Youngster, Halobaim) for auxiliary coverage beyond the main database. All facepacks install to the download folder; the game reads faces directly from there at startup — no cpk.root entry is needed.

Note: Unlike the old SmokePatch facepack, these packs install to the download folder rather than content\faces. No cpk.root entry in sider.ini is needed — the game reads faces directly from the download directory at startup.

Layer 5 — Stadiums

FL26 includes 36 pre-installed stadiums in the base download (11 in the pre-installed Stadium Server v1.60, the rest in cpk). The rows below add per-team assignment and regional high-resolution

stadium packs beyond the built-in set. Download: [SmokePatch FL Sider Stadiums](#) (MediaFire/Mega mirrors + copy-paste map lines).

Mod	Details	Install
Stadium Server (zlac, v1.60)	Sider module for per-team and per-league stadium assignment (unlimited stadiums, map_teams.txt + map_competition.txt). Already pre-installed in FL26 (v1.60, upgraded in FL25) — do not replace it with an older version. Standalone module: pes-files.ru — Stadium Server v1.60 . Server docs + regional packs: SmokePatch FL Sider Stadiums .	Pre-installed — nothing to download. Enable in sider.ini with lua.module = "StadiumServer.lua" (+ lua.module = "lib\commonLib.lua" if required). Configure assignments in map_teams.txt — see the Sider Configuration chapter.
Stadium packs (SmokePatch regional)	High-resolution stadiums + adboards + tunnels, per folder to SiderAddons\content\stadiums\ (FL26 path — older guides say content\stadium-server\), and copy the page's map lines into map_teams.txt. Map format: TeamID, StadiumID, Stadium name, Folder # comment.	Pick a region, extract its stadiums\ (FL26 path — older guides say content\stadium-server\), and copy the page's map lines into map_teams.txt. Map format: TeamID, StadiumID, Stadium name, Folder # comment.

Table 7: Layer 5 — Stadiums

The Stadium Server is pre-installed — confirm it loads (check the Sider overlay in-game) before adding regional packs. Do not configure map_teams.txt until the server module is verified active. If Windows blocks saving map_teams.txt, save to Desktop first, then move it back. **Verify before continuing:** start a kickoff match at a mapped home ground — expect the assigned stadium, not a generic. If generic, check SiderAddons\content\stadiums\map_teams.txt has the team line (see Unmapped-stadiums pitfall).

Layer 6 — Graphics Overhaul

Mod	Details	Install
Soccer Revolution	Lighting overhaul: pitch textures, stadium shadows, and broadcast-style colour grading. Unversioned; confirmed active August 2026. Direct thread: EvoWeb thread 94305 .	Extract to a subdirectory under livecpk\ (e.g. livecpk\soccer-revolution\). Add <code>cpk.root = ".\livecpk\soccer-revolution"</code> to <code>sider.ini</code> .
Jeremiah's Ultra Turfs	Organic non-repeating grass textures with realistic wear patterns, mowing lines, and pitch degradation. By Jeremiah Osoba; Stadium-Server addon. Download: pes-files.ru — Next-Gen FIFA Turf Addon or EvoWeb — search: "Jeremiah Ultra Turfs".	Extract to a subdirectory under livecpk\ (e.g. livecpk\ultra-turfs\). Add <code>cpk.root = ".\livecpk\ultra-turfs"</code> to <code>sider.ini</code> .
Realistic Turf in Full HD	Alternative/companion to Jeremiah's Ultra Turfs. Realistic grass textures in full HD resolution. Available at pesoccerworld.com .	Extract to a subdirectory under livecpk\ (e.g. livecpk\realistic-turf\). Add <code>cpk.root = ".\livecpk\realistic-turf"</code> to <code>sider.ini</code> . Install after Jeremiah's Ultra Turfs — later <code>cpk.root</code> entries override earlier ones. If you prefer this turf to Jeremiah's, place it last in the CPK root chain.
ReShade Preset (Machete Gaming / KnightMD)	Post-processing colour and sharpening preset. Preset: Machete's PES21 ReShade v3 (.ini, MediaFire) (also via Machete Gaming Discord); discussed for FL26 in r/SPFootballLife . ReShade base:	Download the ReShade installer from reshade.me and run it targeting FL 26.exe. Select Direct3D 10/11/12 as the rendering API. Copy the .ini preset file into your FL26

Table 8: Layer 6 — Graphics Overhaul.

root directory. Select it in the ReShade in-game overlay (default: Home key).

Load order note: ReShade runs independently of Sider — it hooks the Direct3D pipeline directly. The `livecpk` entries for Soccer Revolution and the two turf mods load through Sider's CPK root system. Install and verify the CPK root mods before applying ReShade; the preset is tuned to complement the lighting and turf changes. For turf: install both Jeremiah's Ultra Turfs and Realistic Turf, but only enable one as your active turf by placing it later in the CPK root chain — later entries override earlier ones.

Layer 7 — Camera

Mod	Details	Install
Nesa24's Camera Modules	TV-broadcast camera suite with configurable zoom, height, angle, and smooth panning (BroadCastCam.lua + nesalib.lua core). Replaces the default in-game camera options. Download: Sharemods — v3.3, 16.5 MB or EvoWeb — search: "Nesa24 camera".	Merge the archive's modules folder into Sider\. Enable in sider.ini with lua.module = "lib\nesalib.lua" first, then lua.module = "BroadCastCam.lua" (exact filenames may vary — check the archive). Configure camera parameters in-game via the Sider overlay or the module's .ini file.
BroadcastCam Manager v2.0 (Ngysz_419)	External BroadCastCam.ini + BroadCastCam.lua manager (not a Sider module): per-stadium TV-broadcast angles, presets, merge/install, plus v2.0 AI auto-correct that aligns stadium names with your map files. v2.0 archive: 11.81 MB, uploaded 2026-09-19, VirusTotal 0/28 (observed Sep 22). Complements Nesa24's in-game camera tuning above — install Nesa24 modules and the Stadium Server map first. UN-VERIFIED — pending FL26 v2.2 smoke test; scan the binary before running. r/SPFootball-Life post (v1.0: v1.0 post); downloads: v2.0 MediaFire , v1.0 MediaFire .	Extract beside your FL26 install. Point the tool at BroadCastCam.ini plus your stadium mapping file, apply auto-correct, then launch via Sider (as admin) with the in-game camera set to Live Broadcast. No sider.ini changes.

Table 9: Layer 7 — Camera

Verify before continuing: in the Sider overlay (Spacebar), confirm the camera module list shows no errors, then check sider.log has no nesalib/BroadCastCam load errors. If errors, the library line is missing or below the camera line — libraries first. Do not continue until the log is clean.

Layer 8 — Balls

Mod	Details	Install
Ball Server (Hawke/community)	Competition-aware ball selection: loads the correct official ball for each league, cup, and tournament. Bundled in the Essentials Mod Pack (Layer 3) as Ballpack v60 AIO by Hawke. Standalone module + packs: caocacao.net — Hawke ball pack (Modsfire/Sharemods) or EvoWeb — search: “Ball Server sider”. Unversioned Sider module; confirmed active August 2026.	If using the Essentials Mod Pack, Ball Server is already installed — skip this step. Otherwise: place the Ball Server Lua module in Sider\. Enable in sider.ini with <code>lua.module = "BallServer.lua"</code> (plus <code>lua.module = "lib\CommonLib.lua"</code> first if required). In-game, press Spacebar to open the Sider overlay, then press ~ (tilde) to open the OMB.lua menu — Ball Server appears as a configurable module there.
Ballpack Season 2026/27 AIO (All Makers)	2026/27 balls for every major league (Puma Stellar Nitro set, Adidas UCL Pro, Torfabrik, Brillant APS). Replaces the Ball Server ball files wholesale — supersedes the Ballpack v60 AIO bundled in the Essentials Mod Pack (Layer 3). Available at ultigamerz.com .	Replace the Ball Server ball files per the pack’s instructions. Keep Ball Server (<code>lua.module = "BallServer.lua"</code>) enabled — only the ball content changes.

Table 10: Layer 8 — Balls

Note: The Essentials Mod Pack (Layer 3) includes a ball pack as part of its AIO bundle. Ball Server builds on that collection by assigning the correct competition ball automatically. If you skipped Layer 3, ensure ball .cpk files are present in your livecpk tree before enabling the server.

Layer 9 — Gameplay

Mod	Details	Install
Gameplay Loader (Baris, v2.6)	Modular gameplay-switching framework. Lets you swap between gameplay mods without reinstalling. Bundled in the Essentials Mod Pack (Layer 3) with multiple gameplay options pre-loaded. Standalone: caocacao.net — v2.6 (Modsfire/Sharemods) or EvoWeb — search: “Gameplay Loader”.	If using the Essentials Mod Pack, Gameplay Loader is already installed — skip this step. Otherwise: place the Gameplay Loader Lua module in Sider\. Enable in sider.ini with lua.module = "GameplayLoader.lua". Place gameplay mod .dt files in the Loader’s designated subdirectory (typically content\gameplay-loader\).
Realism Gameplay V12 (All Makers)	Primary recommendation — supersedes v10. Holland-lineage gameplay overhaul, September 2026 iteration. Improves player movement, natural animations, ball physics, shooting/finishing, goalkeeper behavior, physical contact, and pitch feel. Explicitly FL26 compatible. Available at Sharemods (mirrors via pesfiles.ru).	• Move the Realism Gameplay V12 folder into livecpk\. • Merge the modules folder contents into Sider\ (all .lua files go here). • Add the v12 cpk.root + lua.module entries from the pack readme to sider.ini (same pattern as v10: one CPK root plus gameplay Lua modules — verify names, they may differ from v10). • Copy the pack’s Data folder .cpk files (e.g. dt18_all.cpk, dt13_all.cpk) into the game’s Data folder, replacing existing files.
AI Manager v2 (Emre Cakir)	Complementary. AI mentality manager that reads match state and adapts team attack/defense levels in real time. Auto mode: losing→attack level 3–4, winning against strong team→defense level 0 in last 10 min. Manual override available. Works alongside any gameplay mod — no conflicts. Available at pesfiles.com (Modsfire + Sharemods mirrors).	• Place AI-Manager.lua in Sider\. • Add to sider.ini under [lua]: lua.module = "AI-Manager.lua". • In-game controls: press 8 to select your team, 9 to toggle auto/manual mode, PageUp/PageDown to adjust attack/defense level in manual mode.

Table 11: Layer 9 — Gameplay

Realism Gameplay V12 (All Makers) is the primary recommendation — the September 2026 Holland-lineage iteration superseding v10, with explicit FL26 compatibility. Verify the v12 module and Data-file list in the pack's readme before swapping (folder and module names may differ from v10). AI Manager v2 adds adaptive AI mentality on top — it runs alongside any gameplay mod, including Realism V12, with zero conflicts. The Gameplay Loader is retained for testing other .dt-based gameplay mods or swapping between gameplay variants. Note that Realism V12 installs directly into Sider (livecpk + Lua modules) and does not use the Gameplay Loader — only .dt-based gameplay mods go through the Loader. **Verify before continuing:** open the Sider overlay (Spacebar) — expect the Gameplay Loader menu plus AI Manager present with no module errors in `sider.log`. Pick a gameplay variant in the Loader and confirm it persists across a restart. If missing, check the `lua.module` lines and `Sider\` files (see Missing-module pitfall).

Layer 10 — Career Depth

Mod	Details	Install
Ultimate Master League (UML) v3	Overhauled career mode: reworked player development curves, 2,800+ player stat adjustments, World Cup 2026 rosters with accurate squads, K League 1, and exclusive facepacks. Developed by UML Team (PogChampion, jovic1901, Daemon, BMKits) and freely distributed via caocacao.net . Explicitly FL26 v2.2 compatible.	UML v3 is a free mod — download the FL Version, EDIT00000000, install instructions, Ball Server fix v3 (PixelDrain) and WC addon fix (Modsfire) from caocacao.net — UML for FL v3 + WC fix. Apply v3's bundled sider.exe/sider.dll as a set. Follow the UML Team's installation guide: database files into content\, Sider modules into Sider\, kit server configuration per the included documentation. UML expects the Essentials Mod Pack (Layer 3) as a prerequisite for kit server and face assignment.
Touchline (ML companion, ASK Andalus)	Free external Master League storyline layer (vo.8.6): stories, press, board memory, staff; form arcs, coaching, LIVE ECONOMY budget — all toggleable. Adds TouchlineCompanion + 3 scripts (MLRuntime.lua, MLImpression.lua, MLRegenAliases.lua) with sider.ini.touchline- <date>.bak backup; careers in content\ml-immersion\profiles. Auto-disables BudgetSetter.lua — crash risk. UNVERIFIED — site names FL26 v1.4 for live features, no v2.2 statement. Download from askandalus.com only.	Close the game, run the installer, point at the folder containing sider.exe. Start the game through Sider, save your ML career once, open Touchline beside the game and connect the career.
Prologue (BAL companion, ASK Andalus)	Free external Become a Legend — storyline layer (vo.6.5): inbox/decisions, sponsors, club/national rankings, honours, invented injuries (none/	Extract the zip (never run from inside it), run the setup, point at the folder containing sider.exe. Start FL26 through Sider, save your

Table 12: Layered Storyline Depth

caocacao.net note: UML v3 is distributed by the UML Team and hosted freely on caocacao.net. Downloads are via PixelDrain (primary files) and Modsfire (WC addon fix). This mod is optional — the base FL26 Master League is fully playable without it. **Verify before continuing (UML only):** boot to the Master League menu with UML applied — expect UML’s league list (incl. K League 1) and exclusive scoreboards. If the game crashes on load, restore the pre-Layer-10 snapshot: UML and the Gondowan EDIT file are mutually exclusive (see conflicts).

Layer 11 — Optional Leagues

Mod	Details	Install
Ultra League Patch (ULP) / community league databases	Community-maintained league expansions adding regional leagues beyond the FL26 base. Liga MX and Chinese Super League are available via separate community database mods. Scope varies by release wave and maintainer — verify current coverage at install time. Active development as of August 2026. Sources: EvoWeb and r/SPFootballLife new posts — no single canonical download; search the current wave at install time.	Follow each mod’s own installation instructions. Most community league databases ship as Sider modules with accompanying cpk.root entries. Install one league database at a time and verify the game boots between each to isolate conflicts. Do not mix league databases from different authors unless explicitly declared compatible.

Table 13: Layer 11 — Optional Leagues

Engine limitation: The FL26 engine does not support a full lower-league pyramid below tier 2. The Championship is the lowest playable division in the English league structure; no League One, League Two, or National League mods exist. Community league databases expand horizontally (adding new top-tier leagues like Liga MX and CSL) rather than vertically (adding promotion/relegation tiers). Accept this constraint before installing — no amount of modding can add a third tier. **Experimental — new-leagues beta (Sep 2026):** Matozanato’s FootballLife-new-leagues beta breaks the 750-club ceiling at runtime via Sider (no .exe/CPK edits) — the only current path to brand-new leagues in Master League. See the [r/SPFootballLife beta post](#) and GitHub (Matozanato/FootballLife-new-leagues). Known walls: 1,536-club season generation, day- 238 career crash, placeholder assets. Test on a copy with a fresh save only; the engine-limitation note above otherwise stands.

Layer 12 — Sleeve Patch & Armband Server

Mod	Details	Install
Sleeve Patch & Armband Server 4.0 AIO	Updated 2026 versions of regular competition badges — refreshes league, cup, and super cup patches across 16+ competitions. Includes FIFA World Cup 2026 badges + champions badge. Replaces outdated default patches with current-season designs; not separate replacement badges. Sider module. Available at pesoccerworld.com .	CRITICAL: Delete any previous version before installing — do not overwrite. Copy content and modules into the Sider directory. Enable <code>lua.module = "SleeveBadge-ArmbandServer.lua"</code> in <code>sider.ini</code> .

Table 14: Layer 12 — Sleeve Patch & Armband Server

Installation order: Install after core visual and gameplay layers are stable. Patches are assigned dynamically per competition. The delete-before-install requirement is critical: stale files from a previous version cause silent failures.

Layer 13 — Soundtrack Server

Mod	Details	Install
Soundtrack Server v8.0 (marcoiacovellio2)	Three curated music collections: 80s (182 songs), Iconic (88 songs), PES+FIFA (97 songs) — 367 tracks total. Favourites system, pre-match intro compatible, Ctrl+F5 live reload. Available at pesoccerworld.com .	Follow the included TXT instructions. Installs as a Sider module, replaces the in-game soundtrack. Ctrl+F5 reloads music live during gameplay.

Table 15: Layer 13 — Soundtrack Server

Note: This is a music replacement, not an audio mixer. It is separate from SoundServer (Layer 2), which controls crowd, referee, and announcer audio. Both coexist — Soundtrack Server handles the playlist, SoundServer handles the in-match mix.

Layer 14 — Kitpacks

Mod	Details	Install
Mega Kitpack V2 2025/26 (FL & UML)	Comprehensive 2025/26 kit pack for FL26 and UML leagues. Available at pesoccerworld.com .	Extract to livecpk\mega-kitpack-v2\ . Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\mega-kitpack-v2" to sider.ini. Install before the DN7 addon.
Mega Kitpack 2025/26 V2 Addon (DN7 Kits)	Supplementary kits by DN7 Kits. Additional 2025/26 kits beyond the V2 base. Available at pesoccerworld.com .	Extract to livecpk\dn7-kits-addon\ . Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\dn7-kits-addon" to sider.ini. Place after V2 base in CPK root chain — later entries take priority.

Table 16: Layer 14 — Kitpacks

Kit load order: The Essentials Mod Pack (Layer 3) includes a base kit set. Place these kitpack cpk.root entries after the Essentials entries so the dedicated kit packs override the base.

Layer 15 — Accessories

Mod	Details	Install
Gloves & Boots Pack (Fallons)	Updated goalkeeper gloves and player boots for the April 2026 window. Available at pesoccerworld.com .	Extract to livecpk\gloves-boots-fallons\ . Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\gloves-boots-fallons" to sider.ini. Place after kitpacks and Essentials in the CPK root chain.

Table 17: Layer 15 — Accessories

Note: The Essentials Mod Pack (Layer 3) bundles an older boots/gloves set. The Fallons pack provides more recent models. Place its cpk.root entry after the Essentials entries so newer accessories override bundled ones.

Layer 16 — Scoreboards & TV Logos

Mod	Details	Install
Mega Scoreboard Pack 2026 v2	Argentina, World Cup 2026, and AFCON scoreboards in a single pack. Sider module with Scoreboard Server + Hexx integration. Available at pes-files.com . UML CONFLICT: UML v3 ships exclusive scoreboards — installing this pack overrides UML's scoreboard assignments. Install only if not using UML.	Enable in sider.ini: lua.module = "common\Scoreboard-Server.lua" and lua.module = "common\Scoreboard-Hexx.lua". Copy scoreboard assets to the designated Sider content folder per the pack's included instructions.
TV Logo Scoreboard FIFA WC 2026	World Cup 2026 TV-style logo overlay scoreboard. Unversioned. Available at pes-files.com .	Copy to matching Sider livecpk folder. If the pack includes a Sider module, enable it in sider.ini.

Table 18: Layer 16 — Scoreboards & TV Logos

Installation order: Install after core visual and gameplay layers are stable. Scoreboard modules load independently via Sider — no CPK root chain considerations. The Mega Scoreboard Pack's Hexx module may conflict with other scoreboard modules (including UML's); enable only one scoreboard system at a time.

Layer 17 — Stadium Additions

Mod	Details	Install
Stadium Pack 4K Turf 2026	Four stadiums — Etihad, Emirates, Parc des Princes, Anfield — with 4K turf textures. 2026 season update. Available at pes-files.com .	Extract to SiderAddons\content\stadiums\ (FL26 path — older guides say content\stadium-server\). The pack includes map_teams.txt entries — merge with your existing file. Confirm stadium IDs don't conflict with the regional packs (Layer 5).
Dirt Stains in Snow Turf 2026	Snow weather turf texture with realistic dirt stain detail. 2026 update. Available at pes-files.com .	Extract to a subdirectory under livecpk\ (e.g. livecpk\snow-turf\). Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\snow-turf" to sider.ini. Place after other turf mods in the CPK root chain — this only affects snow-weather pitches.

Table 19: Layer 17 — Stadium Additions

Stadium load order: The stadium pack adds to SiderAddons\content\stadiums\ alongside the regional packs (Layer 5). Merge map_teams.txt entries carefully — duplicate stadium IDs will cause

assignment conflicts. The snow turf is weather-conditional and won't interfere with dry-weather turf mods.

Layer 18 — Kits & Adboards

Mod	Details	Install
Kitpack Style Collection 2026/27 V16 AIO	Comprehensive kit collection by Karjan for the 2026/27 season. Compatible with all patches including FL26 and UML. Available at pes-files.com .	Extract to a subdirectory under livecpk\ (e.g. livecpk\karjan-kits-v16\). Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\karjan-kits-v16" to sider.ini. Place after Mega Kitpack V2 and DN7 Addon (Layer 14) in the CPK root chain — later entries override earlier ones.
Animated Adboard Pack V2 AIO 2026/27	Animated digital adboards for the 2026/27 season by lanphan09. FL26 compatible. Available at pes-files.com .	Extract to livecpk\Adboard\. Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\Adboard" to sider.ini. Place after the Essentials Mod Pack's adboard entries.
FIFA WC New Adboard 2026	World Cup 2026 themed static/digital adboards. Available at pes-files.com .	Extract to a subdirectory under livecpk\ (e.g. livecpk\wc-adboards\). Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\wc-adboards" to sider.ini. Place after the Animated Adboard Pack — WC boards will appear for World Cup competition matches if the pack is competition-aware.
DN7 FIFA World Cup 2026 Full Kits Pack	All 48 WC teams (+ non-qualifiers): kits, fonts/numbers, shorts/socks, WC hierarchy folders, PANDURO badge-server sleeve badges, referee kits. By DN7 + KitManCal, byBAU, Hawke, PANDURO et al. (corroborated: Kazemario + pesmodding + showcases). WC-tournament use; does not replace club kitpacks. Available at kazemario.com .	Install per the pack's KitServer instructions (content\kit-server\ + map.txt alignment for the WC hierarchy).

Table 20: Layer 18 — Kits & Adboards

Kit load order: The Essentials Mod Pack (Layer 3) and Mega Kitpack V2 (Layer 14) already provide substantial kit coverage. Place Karjan's V16 kitpack last in the CPK root chain so it overrides older kits with 2026/27 designs. For adboards: the Animated Adboard Pack covers league play; the WC adboards are competition-specific and coexist without conflicts.

Layer 19 — Audio Additions

Mod	Details	Install
Realistic Chants Pack 2026	Team-specific chants for England, Argentina, Spain, France, and Italy. Sider module. Complementary to Predator002 (Layer 2) — install alongside for broader chant coverage. Available at pes-files.com .	Enable in sider.ini with <code>lua.module = "chants.lua"</code> . Copy chant audio files to the Sider module's designated directory. This coexists with Predator002 — each module handles different teams and leagues.
Player Enhanced Foul Voices	Player reaction voice samples for fouls — adds grunts, shouts, and protests on heavy tackles. Unversioned. Available at pes-files.com .	Copy to matching Sider livecpk folder.
Mariano Closs V5.5.1	Spanish-language commentary by Mariano Closs. Alternative to the English Commentary v8 (Peter Drury & Jim Beglin). Available at pes-files.com .	Copy commentary files to the game's commentary directory. After install, select Spanish under System Settings > Language > Commentary. This replaces English commentary entirely — not a mix.
Real Atmosphere Announcer Stadium	Stadium PA announcer: goal calls, substitution announcements, added time declarations. Unversioned. Available at pes-files.com .	Copy to matching Sider folders. Works through SoundServer's ambient channel — ensure SoundServer (Layer 2) is installed and active.

Table 21: Layer 19 — Audio Additions

Audio coexistence: The Realistic Chants Pack and Predator002 (Layer 2) serve different teams and can coexist without conflicts. The Mariano Closs commentary is a complete replacement for English commentary — install one, not both. The Stadium Announcer operates through SoundServer's ambient audio channel and complements all other audio mods.

Layer 20 — Immersion & Visuals

Mod	Details	Install
Cutscenes VAR 2026	VAR review cutscenes that trigger during match stoppages. 2026 season update. Available at pes-files.com .	Extract to a subdirectory under livecpk\ (e.g. livecpk\var-cutscenes\). Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\var-cutscenes" to sider.ini.
Dynamic Penalty Camera 2026	Dynamic camera angles for penalty kicks — zooms, pans, and player close-ups during spot-kicks. 2026 update. Available at pes-files.com .	Copy to matching Sider folders. If the pack includes a .lua module, place it in Sider\ and enable in sider.ini.
New Menu PES Street 27	PES Street themed main menu UI — urban/street football aesthetic. 2026/27 season. Available at pes-files.com .	Extract to a subdirectory under livecpk\ (e.g. livecpk\menu-pes-street\). Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\menu-pes-street" to sider.ini. Only one menu theme can be active — this replaces the default FL26 menu.
Body Faces Next-Gen Textures	Next-gen quality body and face texture pack — improves skin detail, muscle definition, and facial texture resolution. Unversioned. Available at pes-files.com .	Extract to a subdirectory under livecpk\ (e.g. livecpk\nextgen-textures\). Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\nextgen-textures" to sider.ini. Place after facepacks (Layer 4) — CPK root priority means these textures override base face textures.
Celebration Mod Shirtless V4.2	Shirtless goal celebration animations — players remove shirts on big goals. v4.2. Available at pes-files.com .	Copy to matching Sider folders. May include a Sider module — check the archive for .lua files and enable in sider.ini if present.
GP Prematch Animations 2026	Pre-match sequences: tunnel walkouts, lineup presentations, and warm-up animations. 2026 season update. Available at pes-files.com .	Extract to a subdirectory under livecpk\ (e.g. livecpk\prematch-anim\). Add cpk.root = ".\livecpk\prematch-anim" to sider.ini.

Table 22: Layer 20 — Immersion & Visuals

Immersion stack note: These mods are cosmetic and independent — they don't interact with gameplay, career, or database systems. Install in any order within the layer. All install via livecpk with cpk.root entries. The menu theme is mutually exclusive with any other menu mod; the rest coexist without conflicts.

Known Limitations

No full lower-league pyramid. [EvoWeb](#) and [caocacao.net](#) have confirmed this is an engine-level restriction, not a modding gap. The English Championship is the lowest tier 2 league; the German 2. Bundesliga and Spanish LaLiga 2 are similarly the floor for their pyramids. Installing league database mods will not add lower divisions.

UML v3 is now free. Ultimate Master League was previously paid but is now freely distributed on [caocacao.net](#) with PixelDrain downloads. Every mod in this stack is free. The base FL26 Master League provides a solid career experience without UML — UML adds depth (player development overhaul, stat tuning, exclusive facepacks) and is fully optional.

No classic or legendary teams. FL26 does not ship classic teams (Classic World XI, Classic European XI, retro national squads), and no community mod reliably adds them. Attempts exist on [EvoWeb](#) but suffer from broken face assignments, misaligned stats, and database conflicts. Treat any classic-team mod as experimental and back up your install before trying one.

Save Compatibility Warning

FL26 updates (for example, v2.2 → v2.3) are not save-compatible with Master League and Become a Legend careers. An update can introduce database changes — roster moves, stat adjustments, league structure modifications — that invalidate existing save files. The game will either crash on load or display corrupted career data.

Before applying an FL26 update: Back up your Documents\KONAMI\ save directory and your current FL 26.exe. This lets you revert to the previous version and resume your career if the update breaks saves.

For career stability: Lock your FL26 install at v2.2 for the duration of a long-term Master League or Become a Legend save. Do not apply mid-season patches, league database swaps, or FL26 updates while a career is active. If you want to experiment with newer versions, maintain a parallel install on a separate drive or rename your existing FL26 directory, install the new version fresh, and keep the v2.2 install untouched for your active career.

Sider Configuration

How Sider Works

Sider is a runtime injection framework for PES 2021 / FL26. It loads *before the game* and patches the game's memory-space to insert custom assets — stadiums, faces, audio files, gameplay tweaks, and camera modules — without modifying the game's original files.

This matters because FL26 ships with over 20 GB of bundled content in .cpk archives. Sider layers community content *on top of* that archive, respecting load order so mods can selectively override specific assets without unpacking or replacing dozens of gigabytes of stock data.

The framework is Lua-scriptable: modules can hook into in-game events, present overlay menus, and react to match state. The Stadium Server, for example, reads the match fixture at kickoff, looks up the home team in its `map_teams.txt`, and injects the corresponding stadium model before the game engine finishes loading.

To use Sider: launch the game via `FL_2026_start.exe`, never `FL_26.exe`. If you launch through the game executable directly, Sider never loads and none of the installed mods are injected.

The `sider.ini` File

`sider.ini` lives in the FL26 root directory and controls every aspect of Sider's behavior at startup. It is a plain-text INI file with sections delimited by `[section]` headers. Two sections matter for this mod guide: `[lua]` and `[cpk]`.

+`[lua]` — Module Registration

Each `lua.module` line loads a Sider Lua module at startup. Modules are read from the `Sider\` directory. The order of entries *does not matter* — *with one exception*: library modules must load before the modules that need them (`lib\nesalib.lua` before `BroadCastCam.lua`; `lib\CommonLib.lua` before `BallServer.lua`). Keep libraries at the top of the `[lua]` section and everything else can follow in any order.

Module	Entry	What It Does
SoundServer	lua.module = "SoundServer.lua"	Per-channel audio mixer — crowd, referee, announcer, ambient. Open in-game via Sider overlay to balance levels.
Stadium Server	lua.module = "StadiumServer.lua"	Per-team / per-league stadium assignment. Reads SiderAddons\content\stadiums\map_t at kick-off and injects the correct stadium.
Ball Server	lua.module = "lib\CommonLib.lua" then lua.module = "BallServer.lua"	Competition-aware ball selection.

Table 23: Lua Modules in Our Stack

This section also carries the master enable switch:

```
[lua]
lua.enabled = 1
```

If `lua.enabled` is set to 0, no Lua modules load — even if they have `lua.module` entries below. Sider boots but injects nothing. This is useful for debugging: set it to 0 temporarily to isolate whether a problem is mod-related.

+`[cpk]` — Live CPK Roots

Each `cpk.root` line registers a filesystem directory that Sider scans and overlays onto the game's virtual CPK archive. The directory must contain assets in the game's internal folder structure (e.g., `common\render\model\player\face\real` for face files).

Order matters. The game resolves conflicts the same way a file system resolves overlapping mounts: a later `cpk.root` declaration overrides an earlier one. If two CPK roots both supply `common\render\model\player\face\real\12345\face.fpk`, the file from the *last* matching `cpk.root` wins.

This is the opposite of how many game mod managers work (loose files override archives). In Sider, later entries are higher priority. Use this intentionally: put your base asset packs early and your fine-tuning overrides later.

```
[cpk]
cpk.root = ".\livecpk\preds-root"
cpk.root = ".\livecpk\referee-whistle"
cpk.root = ".\livecpk\atmosphere-overhaul"
```

Complete `sider.ini` template for this mod stack:

Entry	Purpose
<code>lua.enabled = 1</code>	Master enable switch for all Lua modules.
<code>lua.module = "lib\CommonLib.lua"</code>	Library — must load before BallServer.
<code>lua.module = "lib\nesalib.lua"</code>	Library — must load before BroadCastCam.
<code>lua.module = "SoundServer.lua"</code>	Audio mixing framework — volume control per channel.
<code>lua.module = "StadiumServer.lua"</code>	Stadium assignment per team and league.
<code>lua.module = "BallServer.lua"</code>	Competition-aware ball selection.
<code>lua.module = "GameplayLoader.lua"</code>	Gameplay mod switcher — activate one mod at a time.
<code>lua.module = "BroadCastCam.lua"</code>	Camera tuning modules by nesa24.
<code>cpk.root = ".\livecpk\preds-root"</code>	Predator002 Chant Pack V8 — team-specific chants + ChantsBase ambient crowd.
<code>cpk.root = ".\livecpk\referee-whistle"</code>	Referee Whistle Mod — high-fidelity whistle samples.
<code>cpk.root = ".\livecpk\atmosphere-overhaul"</code>	Atmosphere / Stadium Sound Overhaul — goal reactions, jeers, crowd swells.
—	Facepack: Mega Facepack V4/V5 installs to download\ — no <code>cpk.root</code> entry needed. FL26 reads faces directly from the download folder at startup. <i>Remove any old <code>cpk.root = ".\content\faces"</code> line if migrating from the SmokePatch facepack.</i>

Table 24: Complete sider.ini — Our Mod Stack

Why faces load from download folder: The Football4Life facepacks (Mega Facepack V4/V5 and Facepack v2) install to the SP Football Life 26\download\ directory, which FL26 reads natively at startup — no `cpk.root` entry is required. If you are migrating from the old SmokePatch Facepack AIO, remove the `cpk.root = ".\content\faces"` line from your sider.ini and delete the `content\faces\` folder to free disk space.

Common Pitfalls

Unmapped stadiums: If a team plays at a generic stadium instead of its real-world ground, the Stadium Server's `map_teams.txt` is missing or outdated for that team. Check `SiderAddons\content\stadiums\map_teams.txt`. Each line maps a team ID to a stadium folder: 128, 009, Stamford Bridge, Chelsea\. The file format is team ID, stadium ID, stadium name, stadium folder path — one line per assignment.

Faces not loading: Faces install to SP Football Life 26\download\ — there is no `cpk.root` entry for faces, so a missing `cpk.root` is never the cause. Check: (a) the pack was extracted to `download\` (not a nested subfolder); (b) `01_smkdb_fa7.cpk` (SmokePatch) or the facepack folders are directly in `download\`; (c) no stale `cpk.root = ".\content\faces"` line from a SmokePatch migration is present — remove it if so. See the faces note above.

Sider not injecting: The game is being launched through `FL_26.exe` instead of `FL_2026_start.exe`. The launcher must be the parent process so Sider can initialize. If you are using a desktop shortcut, edit the shortcut target to point to `FL_2026_start.exe`, not the game executable. If you run the game through a launcher (Steam, Playnite), configure it to launch `FL_2026_start.exe`.

Module conflicts — gameplay mods: Realism Gameplay V12 installs as a Sider livecpk overlay with multiple Lua modules — it does not use the Gameplay Loader. AI Manager v2 runs as a stand-alone Lua module alongside it without conflicts. The Gameplay Loader remains available for testing other .dt-based gameplay mods. Only one .dt-based gameplay mod can be active via the Gameplay Loader at a time — the second activation replaces the first. In-game via the Sider overlay: Spacebar to open the overlay, navigate to Gameplay Loader, pick one. This setting persists across sessions.

Black screen on launch: A malformed sider.ini entry can prevent the game from starting. Most common culprit: a cpk.root or lua.module line with a backslash instead of a forward slash in a path. Sider expects Windows-style paths (.\\livecpk\\faces) and Lua-style dot separators for modules (StadiumServer.lua). If you see a black screen with no error, rename or remove sider.ini temporarily and confirm the game boots without it — then rebuild the file entry by entry to isolate the bad line.

Missing module file: If a lua.module entry references a .lua file that does not exist in Sider\\, Sider logs the error to its console and skips that module. The game still boots. Check sider.log in the FL26 root for module load errors.

Backup Strategy

A broken sider.ini can cost you an evening of troubleshooting. A working sider.ini is a precious artifact. Treat it accordingly.

Before each major layer of the installation guide, create a snapshot:

```
# In your FL26 root directory
```

```
# Before Layer N:
```

```
7z a sider-backup-layerN.zip sider.ini SiderAddons\\ Sider\\ livecpk\\ content\\
```

This zips the entire mod-loading infrastructure — Sider configuration, all module files, and every livecpk/content root — into one archive. If a later layer breaks something, restore:

```
7z x sider-backup-layerN.zip -o." -aoa
```

Use -aoa (overwrite all) to force-restore every file to the snapshot state.

Minimum backup: If full archives are impractical (the facepack and stadium pack alone exceed 40 GB), back up at least:

- sider.ini — the single most valuable file; 2 KB that controls your entire mod stack
- Sider\\ — all Lua module files; under 1 MB
- SiderAddons\\content\\stadiums\\map_teams.txt — hours of manual team-to-stadium mapping

Timestamp and label: Naming snapshot archives descriptively saves time. Example: sider-backup-layer4-faces-20260810.zip tells you exactly what it contains and when it was made. Store snapshots outside the FL26 root directory so they are not accidentally deleted during uninstall or mod cleanup.

Manager's Dossier

Before You Start

If you have never played a PES game before, you are in for something different. Football Life descends from PES 2021, which means its DNA is built on deliberate, physics-driven football rather than the rapid, animation-locked feel of other titles. The ball has weight. Player momentum matters. A rushed pass from an off-balance midfielder will come off differently than the same pass delivered by a centre-back in acres of space. This is not a bug — it is the core of the game. Lean into it.

Controller Setup

FL26 supports Xbox controllers natively. Plug in an Xbox One or Series controller and the game recognises it immediately, with all button prompts matching the controller face.

PlayStation controllers need a translation layer. Neither DualShock 4 nor DualSense are natively supported — the game will see them as generic DirectInput devices and button prompts will be garbled. You have two reliable options:

DS4Windows: A free, mature tool that presents your PlayStation controller to Windows as a virtual Xbox 360 pad. Install DS4Windows, pair your controller via Bluetooth or USB, and check the Controllers tab to confirm it is emulating an Xbox 360 pad. Button prompts in-game will show Xbox glyphs.

Steam Input: Add `FL_2026_start.exe` as a non-Steam game. In Steam Big Picture Mode, enable PlayStation Configuration Support under Controller Settings. The overlay translates PS inputs to XInput. This approach is less reliable than DS4Windows for FL26 specifically — some users report intermittent disconnection when the Sider overlay is also active — but it requires no third-party driver installation.

Keyboard is a handicap. FL26 processes input on an analogue level — dribbling precision, pass weight, and shot placement all depend on how far you push the left stick and how much pressure you apply to the trigger. A keyboard reduces all of this to binary on/off states. You can play with a keyboard, but you will lose nuance in every phase of play. Even an inexpensive wired Xbox 360 controller will improve the experience more than any graphics mod.

Difficulty Selection

Start on Regular or Professional. These settings give the AI credible build-up play without the input-reading that appears on Superstar and Legend difficulties. Move up when matches feel comfortable at 8–10 minutes per half. The jump from Professional to Superstar is the steepest in the game — do not be surprised if your first Superstar match ends 4–0 to a mid-table side. This is normal output from the difficulty scaling, not a reflection of your ability.

Controls Primer

FL26 inherits PES 2021's control scheme. If you have played FIFA for years, the muscle memory will fight you for the first few sessions. Stick with it — the layout is internally consistent and rewards practice.

Core Controls (Attack)

The face buttons follow the PES convention: **A** (X on PlayStation glyphs) is the through-ball, not the pass. This trips up FIFA migrants constantly. Commit it to memory early.

- **X** — short pass / ground pass. Hold for a firmer pass; tap for a light one. Direction and power are independent: aim with the left stick, weight with how long you hold the button.

- **A** — through-ball. Sends the ball into space ahead of a teammate. Use when a runner is making a diagonal break behind the defensive line. Do not use when the receiver is standing still and marked — it will roll straight to the defender.
- **Y** — lobbed through-ball / high pass. Hold longer for a deeper flight. Effective over a high defensive line, but easily intercepted against a compact low block.
- **B** — shoot. Power is linear to hold duration. The left stick direction at the moment of contact determines placement: push toward the far post for a placed finish, push away for a driven shot across goal.
- **RB + B** — finesse / curled shot. Slower release but bends around the keeper. Use from the edge of the box when cutting inside onto the stronger foot.
- **LB + Y** — early cross. Sends a dipping ball into the box from deeper positions. More effective than a standard cross when the winger has not yet reached the byline.
- **LT** — close control / shield. Hold to keep the ball tight when receiving a pass under pressure. Also used to hold off a defender with your back to goal.

Core Controls (Defence)

- **A** — pressure / contain. The nearest AI teammate will close down the ball carrier. Use this to apply second-man pressure while you control a different defender cutting off a passing lane.
- **X** — standing tackle. Time the button press with the opponent's touch, not their body position. A mistimed standing tackle on a quick winger with high dribbling stats is a yellow card waiting to happen.
- **B** — sliding tackle. Last resort. Recovery time after a missed slide tackle is long enough for the attacker to create a scoring chance. Only use when you have cover behind you or absolutely must stop a shot.
- **RB** — sprint. Hold to chase. Be aware that sprinting while jockeying makes your defender easier to turn — a standing defender has faster lateral movement than a sprinting one.
- **RT + LT** — super cancel. This is one of the three most important mechanics in the game. Hold both triggers simultaneously to override the game's assisted player movement. Use it to manually reposition a defender who is auto-tracking a run, to abort a triggered through-ball animation, or to steer a receiving player toward the ball instead of waiting for it to arrive. Without super cancel, you are at the mercy of the CPU's pathing. With it, you control your player.

The Tactical D-Pad

The D-pad is your in-match tactical interface. While play is live, pressing up or down on the D-pad cycles through two systems:

Attack/Defence Level: Tapping up or down without holding any modifier adjusts your team's overall mentality on a five-point scale, from 1 (ultra-defensive, everyone behind the ball) to 5 (ultra-attacking, full-backs pushed to the byline). The current level appears briefly as a bar next to the scoreboard. Each increment shifts your defensive line, pressing intensity, and player runs forward. A one-level change is subtle; a three-level swing from 2 to 5 is transformative. Use levels 1–2 when protecting a lead in the final 10 minutes. Use levels 4–5 when chasing a goal.

Fluid Formation Switching: Holding LT and pressing up or down on the D-pad cycles through your three preset tactics — kick-off, in-possession, and out-of-possession. The active tactic name appears briefly on screen. Covered in detail in the Tactics section below, but the short version: you can set different formations for when you have the ball and when you do not, then switch between them mid-match with the D-pad.

Off-Ball Movement

Football is played off the ball. FL26 gives you tools to influence what happens away from the carrier:

Teammate Pressure (Square / X on PS): Holding this button sends the nearest AI teammate to press the ball carrier while you continue to control your selected player. This is your primary defensive tool. Use it to apply a two-man press — you cut off the obvious passing lane, the AI teammate closes the carrier. It drains the pressing player's stamina, so do not hold it continuously. Use it in bursts when the opponent receives the ball facing their own goal or when they are isolated on the wing.

Trigger Run (LB): Flick the right stick toward a teammate after passing to send them on a forward run, or tap LB while aiming the left stick at a teammate to trigger their run manually. Essential for breaking down a parked bus — without triggered runs, your forwards will stand still against a low block.

Super Cancel (RT + LT): Beyond its defensive uses, super cancel lets you manually chase a loose ball that the CPU would otherwise concede as “belongs” to the opponent. In a 50-50 situation, the player who reaches the ball first wins — and super cancel gets you there faster than assisted movement.

Set Pieces

Free kicks: Aim with the left stick before the run-up. The aiming reticle shows where the ball will start its flight, not where it ends — curl and dip happen after the kick. Hold up on the left stick during the shot for dip (the ball rises then drops sharply — best from 18–25 yards), hold left or right for curve, and hold up on the right stick for a knuckleball (unpredictable flight; effective from distance). Power: roughly 40–50% bar for a dipping shot from 25 yards, 60–70% for a driven shot.

Corner kicks: After the camera settles, you can select a receiver with the right stick before taking the corner — this cycles through players in the box and lets you aim a near-post, far-post, or penalty-spot delivery to a specific target. In-swinging corners (right-footed from the left side, left-footed from the right) are statistically more dangerous. Aim near the penalty spot with 50–60% power for the highest conversion rate against default AI defending.

Penalties: The composure circle shrinks and expands around the reticle. Press shoot when the circle is smallest for maximum accuracy. Direction is applied with the left stick after power is set — do not aim before the run-up, as this telegraphs your shot to a human opponent.

Tactics System

Tactics in FL26 are set in the Game Plan menu before each match. You can save up to three preset game plans and switch between them mid-match via the tactical D-pad. The system rewards coherence — a tactic with complementary instructions will outperform one with conflicting settings, even if the individual numbers look better.

Fluid vs Fixed Formations

A **fixed formation** uses the same shape in all phases. Your 4-3-3 is a 4-3-3 when you have the ball, when you lose it, and when the opponent is building up. Simple, predictable, and easy to manage. Recommended while you are learning the game.

A **fluid formation** assigns different shapes to different phases:

- **Kick-Off:** The default shape shown on the formation screen. Used at restarts and when neither team has clear possession.
- **In-Possession:** The shape your team shifts into when you have the ball. Typically more expansive — full-backs become wing-backs, a holding midfielder steps into the attack, or a wide forward tucks inside.
- **Out-of-Possession:** The shape your team shifts into when defending. Typically more compact — wingers drop to form a midfield five, a striker drops into the hole.

A classic example: a 4-3-3 kick-off shape that becomes a 3-2-5 in possession (one full-back steps into midfield, the opposite winger pushes high and wide) and a 4-5-1 out of possession (both wingers

track back to form a flat midfield five). Setting this up takes five minutes in the Game Plan screen. The tactical D-pad then lets you cycle through these shapes during play.

Fluid formations consume team spirit. A team with low cohesion will lose shape during transitions — players will be caught between two positions and arrive late. Do not enable fluid formations with a newly assembled squad. Build familiarity first.

Advanced Instructions

Each player in your formation can receive up to two advanced instructions under the Player Settings tab. These are not cosmetic — they meaningfully alter behaviour:

- **Tight Marking:** The selected player will stick to a designated opponent regardless of your team shape. Effective for neutralising a single creative threat (a deep-lying playmaker, an inverted winger who drifts inside). Costs stamina and can pull your shape apart if the marked player drags your defender out of position.
- **Counter Target:** A forward who stays high and central when you are defending, ready to receive a direct ball after a turnover. Requires a physically strong striker with good hold-up play. Useless on a small, quick forward who gets bullied off the ball while waiting for support.
- **Defensive / Offensive on Set Pieces:** Designates which centre-backs go forward for corners and free kicks. By default, anyone over 185 cm with heading stats above 75 will push up. Override this if you want a specific aerial threat attacking every set piece.

Team instructions are set in the Game Plan's Advanced Instructions tab:

- **Defensive Line Depth:** Scale of 1–10. A high line (7–10) compresses space but leaves you vulnerable to through-balls behind the defence. A low line (1–4) protects against pace but invites pressure and gives the opponent time on the ball in midfield. Most balanced tactics sit at 5–6.
- **Compactness:** Scale of 1–10. Determines the horizontal and vertical spacing between your defensive and midfield lines. High compactness (7–10) denies central passing lanes and forces the opponent wide — effective against possession-based teams. Low compactness (1–4) spreads your lines, covering more pitch width at the cost of gaps between them.
- **Pressing Intensity:** How aggressively your players close down. Aggressive pressing wears out your squad — expect noticeable stamina drop-off after 60 minutes if you press high. Conservative pressing conserves energy but concedes territorial control.

Team Spirit & Familiarity

Team spirit is a numeric score from 0–99 that gates the effectiveness of every tactical instruction you set. A tactic with 99 spirit plays fluidly — players anticipate each other's runs, transitions are crisp, and offside traps fire in unison. The same tactic with 40 spirit plays like strangers in the same kit.

Spirit builds over time through three mechanisms:

1. **Match experience:** Playing matches while using a tactic raises familiarity with it. This is the primary driver.
2. **Player affinity:** A player whose registered position matches their tactical role gains familiarity faster. Playing a natural winger at full-back will slow spirit growth for that flank.
3. **Team role compatibility:** Players with complementary team roles (bandiera, maestro, etc.) accelerate spirit gain for nearby positions. Covered in the Training section.

Changing your formation, instructions, or starting lineup resets some familiarity — small tweaks cost a few points; a complete tactical overhaul drops spirit significantly. Do not radically alter your game plan mid-season unless you are willing to absorb 5–10 matches of reduced cohesion.

Scouting & Youth Academy

Scouting is how you find players. The transfer market alone shows you established names; the scout network reveals the teenagers at Racing Club and Cruzeiro who will be world-class in three seasons.

Building Your Scout Network

In Master League, you hire scouts and assign them to regions. Each scout has three attributes:

- **Experience:** How fast they produce reports. A level-5 scout returns full evaluations within weeks; a level-1 scout takes months to provide the same detail.
- **Judgement:** How accurately they assess a player's current and potential ability. Low judgement means the star ratings in their reports may be off by half a star or more. Do not spend transfer budget on a four-star report from a scout with level-1 judgement.
- **Negotiation:** How effectively they handle transfer talks. A good negotiator can lower the selling club's asking price and the player's wage demands. A poor negotiator may get the deal done but at a premium.

Each scout covers one region at a time. Regions are broad — “South America,” “Central Europe,” “West Africa” — and the pool of discovered players grows the longer a scout stays assigned. Rotate scouts between regions every few months to maintain a diverse pipeline, but do not yank a scout out of a region mid-search — you lose the accumulated scouting progress.

Reading Scout Reports

A completed report shows:

- **Overall Rating:** Expressed in stars (1–5). This is the scout's estimate of the player's current ability relative to your squad. A three-star player is roughly rotation quality; a four-star player is a probable starter.
- **Potential Rating:** Also in stars. The scout's estimate of where this player peaks. A 21-year-old with 2 stars current and 4.5 stars potential is a development target.
- **Attribute Range:** Instead of exact numbers, unscouted players show attribute ranges (for example, Finishing 72–80). The range narrows as the report progresses. A narrow range means the scout is confident; a wide range (70–88) means they need more time.
- **Playing Style & Skills:** The scout identifies traits (Mazing Run, Pinpoint Crossing, etc.) and player skills. These are binary — a player either has a skill or does not — so they are accurate immediately, unlike attribute estimates.

Star ratings are relative to your team. A 4-star player for a mid-table LaLiga side might be a 2.5-star player for Real Madrid. The stars tell you how a player fits your current squad, not how good they are in absolute terms.

UML Scout Improvements

If you are running Ultimate Master League v3, the scouting system receives substantial upgrades:

- Scout reports include **hidden attributes** — injury proneness, consistency, and weak-foot accuracy. In the base game these are invisible until you sign the player. UML surfaces them during scouting.
- **Youth player generation** is weighted toward real-world footballing nations, producing more credible wonderkid distributions. You will still see the occasional 16-year-old Thai goalkeeper with world-class potential, but less frequently.
- **Scout specialisation:** UML scouts can develop affinity for specific regions, producing faster and more accurate reports the longer they stay assigned there. A scout who has spent two seasons in South America will outperform a scout of equal stats who just arrived.

Youth Academy & Wonderkids

Your youth academy produces regens and newgens — regenerated and newly generated players who enter the game world as free agents or through club academies. The key to squad-building is identifying wonderkids before they become famous.

A wonderkid is a player aged 16–21 with:

- **High potential stat:** Look for the potential ceiling in the scout report. Anything above 85 is development-worthy. Above 90 is a probable star.
- **Position-relevant attributes above average for their age:** A 17-year-old centre-back with 75+ defensive awareness and 70+ physical contact is a rare asset. A 17-year-old winger with 80+ speed and 65+ dribbling is development-ready.
- **Playing style that fits your system:** A wonderkid with “Classic No. 10” in a system that does not use an attacking midfielder is a poor fit. The player’s style matters as much as their numbers. The youth academy produces better intake when your club has high reputation, a strong scout network, and youth facility investment (a budget allocation you set at the start of each season). Relegation-threatened clubs produce fewer high-potential graduates than Champions League regulars — this is by design, not random chance.

Transfer Market

The transfer system in Master League models real-world negotiation more faithfully than any other football game on the market. You can lowball, get counter-offered, include clauses, and lose a player to a rival club because you took too long to respond.

The Negotiation Flow

1. **Scout a target.** You need at least a partial scout report before a club will entertain your inquiry. An unscouted player with question marks over their attributes will not return useful negotiation data.
2. **Make an inquiry.** This asks the selling club for a rough price. It costs nothing and commits you to nothing. Use it to gauge whether a player is in your budget before investing negotiation time.
3. **Submit a bid.** The formal offer. You set the transfer fee, any clauses, and the payment structure. The selling club can accept, reject, or counter. A counter-offer usually arrives within a few in-game days — do not expect instant responses for high-value transfers.
4. **Negotiate personal terms.** Once the club accepts, you negotiate wages, contract length, squad role, and release clause with the player. The player’s agent has their own personality — some are flexible, some walk away if you push too hard.
5. **Medical and confirmation.** The transfer completes and the player joins at the next window opening (or immediately if the window is open).

Release Clauses

In **LaLiga**, every player contract must include a release clause by league regulation. This means Spanish clubs cannot refuse to sell if you meet the clause value — no negotiation, no counter-offer. You pay the release clause, the player decides whether to join, and the selling club has no say. This is a double-edged sword. When buying from Spain, you can bypass a stubborn selling club by triggering the clause. When selling to a richer club, they can do the same to you. Before signing a player to a LaLiga club, set the release clause high enough that losing them would at least fund a replacement. A release clause of 1.5–2x the player’s market value is a safe minimum. In other leagues, release clauses are optional. Including one makes the player more willing to sign (it is an escape hatch if the club underperforms). Excluding one gives you control — no one takes your star striker without your consent.

Budget Management

Your club operates with two separate but linked budgets:

- **Transfer Budget:** How much you can spend on transfer fees. Unused transfer budget rolls into the next season in reduced form (roughly 60–70% of the surplus), so do not hoard it — spend what you need.

- **Wage Budget:** How much you can spend on player salaries, expressed as a total annual cap. Exceeding the wage budget blocks new signings and triggers board discontent.

A **budget slider** in the Finances menu lets you convert between the two. Shifting funds from transfer to wage budget (to accommodate a marquee free agent) or from wage to transfer budget (to fund a deadline-day signing) is a standard management move. The conversion rate is not 1:1 — expect to lose roughly 10–15% in the shift. Do not toggle it repeatedly; the loss compounds.

Sell-On Clauses & Loans

Sell-on clauses entitle you to a percentage of the player's next transfer fee. If you sell a young player with 20% sell-on to a mid-table club and they later sell him for 80 million, you receive 16 million. Sell-on clauses reduce the upfront fee a buying club is willing to pay, so they are best used when selling developing players whose value is likely to rise — not when offloading a 32-year-old on the decline.

Loan-to-buy is a two-stage transfer: the player joins on loan for the current season with an obligation or option to buy at a pre-agreed fee. An obligation means the transfer is mandatory at the end of the loan; an option means you can walk away. Loan-to-buy lets you defer the transfer fee into next season's budget, which is useful when you have identified a target but have exhausted the current window's funds. The loan fee is typically 10–20% of the agreed purchase price and is non-refundable if you decline the option.

Loans (standard): You can loan players for a season without a purchase clause. The receiving club pays a loan fee plus some or all of the player's wages. Use loans to give young players match experience at a lower-division club (they develop faster playing 40 matches on loan than sitting on your bench) or to plug a short-term gap without committing transfer budget.

Negotiation Timing

The transfer window closes on a fixed in-game date. Negotiations that are in progress when the window closes can complete — but only if the bid was accepted before the deadline. An inquiry sent at 11 PM on deadline day will not result in a completed transfer. Begin serious negotiations at least five in-game days before the window closes. The AI takes longer to respond to bids involving high-value players, multiple clauses, or rival clubs.

Training & Development

Player development in FL26 is organic — players improve by playing matches at an appropriate level. There is no “training drill” minigame. The system rewards squad planning and patience.

Growth Curves

Every player follows a growth curve that determines when their attributes rise, plateau, and decline. The curve is visible on the Player Development screen as a graph with three phases:

- **Growth Phase:** Attributes increase. Playing time accelerates growth; bench-warming stalls it. A 19-year-old who plays 40 matches in a season will develop faster than an equally talented 19-year-old who plays 8.
- **Peak Phase:** Attributes stabilise. Development slows to near zero. The player maintains their current level as long as they play regularly. Extended injuries during the peak phase can trigger early decline.
- **Decline Phase:** Attributes begin falling, starting with physical stats (speed, acceleration, stamina) and progressing to technical attributes over subsequent seasons. Decline is gradual — a 34-year-old midfielder does not become useless overnight, but their pace will drop 1–2 points per season.

There are three broad curve archetypes:

- **Early Peak (18–23):** The player reaches their ceiling quickly and plateaus through their mid-20s before declining earlier than average. Common among explosive wingers and pace-dependent

forwards. These players deliver immediate impact but have shorter useful careers. Plan to sell around age 28–29, before the decline accelerates.

- **Steady (20–29):** The most common curve. Gradual improvement through the early 20s, a long plateau through the prime years, and gentle decline starting around 30. Most midfielders and full-backs follow this pattern.
- **Late Bloomer (24–29):** Slow initial development followed by sustained growth well into the late 20s. Central defenders, goalkeepers, and deep-lying playmakers often follow this curve. A late-blooming centre-back at 23 may look unremarkable and become elite at 27. Do not sell these players early.

UML v3 adds more granular curve variants, including “Second Peak” (decline followed by a late-career resurgence — common for holding midfielders who transition to centre-back) and “Injury-Prone” (sharper decline after each significant injury).

Peak Ages by Position

These are averages, not hard rules, but they inform transfer and contract strategy:

- **Wingers / Wide Forwards:** Peak 23–27. Speed-dependent roles decline earliest. A winger who relies on pace will be noticeably different at 30 than at 25. Technical wingers (those with high dribbling and crossing rather than pure speed) age more gracefully.
- **Strikers:** Peak 25–29. Physical strikers peak earlier; technical strikers (target men, false nines) hold their level longer. A poacher at 32 is rare and valuable.
- **Full-Backs:** Peak 24–28. Similar to wingers in the speed dependency, but position compensates with defensive attributes that peak later than raw pace.
- **Central Midfielders:** Peak 25–30. Box-to-box players peak earlier (stamina-dependent); deep-lying playmakers peak later (position-dependent). A 33-year-old regista can still dictate a match.
- **Centre-Backs:** Peak 27–32. The latest-peaking outfield position. Physical attributes peak around 27; positioning, anticipation, and defensive awareness continue improving into the early 30s. A 33-year-old centre-back with high defensive stats is still a credible starter.
- **Goalkeepers:** Peak 28–34. Keepers develop slowly and decline slowly. A 36-year-old goalkeeper with 85+ reflexes and positioning is still elite. Do not replace a performing goalkeeper just because of age.

Position Training

You can train a player in a new position. The player must play matches in the target position for the training to take effect — setting it in the menu without giving them minutes does nothing.

- **Adjacent positions** (RB → RWB, CM → DM, LW → LM) take 4–8 weeks of regular playing time to register as “accomplished.”
- **Moderate shifts** (RB → CB, CM → AM, LW → CF) take 8–16 weeks.
- **Major shifts** (CB → ST, GK → anywhere) may never fully register. The game will show the player as “awkward” in the position indefinitely.

A player’s positional affinity rating (visible on their player card) affects how quickly they adapt. A “Versatile” player learns new positions faster. A player with only one registered position may resist training altogether.

Mentoring & Team Roles

Veteran players with high team spirit and leadership attributes can mentor younger players in the same position group. Mentoring passes:

- **Playing styles:** A younger player can adopt the mentor’s playing style over several months. This is the primary way to shape a wonderkid’s role to fit your system.

- **Player skills:** Rare and useful skills (One-Touch Pass, Man Marking, Long Range Shooting) can transfer through mentoring. The mentor must have the skill and the younger player must have a compatible position.
- **Mental attributes:** Tenacity, mentality, and teamwork values gradually shift toward the mentor's levels.

The mentor's **team role** matters. Roles are earned over time and reflect a player's standing in the squad:

- **Bandiera:** The club icon. Fastest mentoring speed, highest team spirit aura. Typically a long-serving player with 100+ appearances.
- **Maestro:** The technical leader. Strong mentoring influence on players in the same position group. A Maestro midfielder accelerates the development of every midfielder in the squad.
- **Leader / General:** Moderate mentoring influence. Multiple Leaders stack additively — a squad with three Leaders develops young players faster than one with a single Bandiera and no other senior figures.

Mentoring relationships appear in the Squad menu. Pair a 30+ year-old with the appropriate role and a teenager in the same position group, and the development screen will show a mentoring link within a few weeks.

Match-Day Management

A well-built squad and a sound tactic are half the battle. Managing the 90 minutes is the other half. FL26's match engine punishes neglect — a tired player, a morale dip, or a tactical mismatch left unchecked will produce goals for the opposition.

Pre-Match: Game Plans & Form Arrows

Before each match, the Game Plan screen displays your squad with **form arrows** for every player:

- **↑ (green, angled up):** The player is in form. All attributes receive a +2–4 boost. An in-form 78-rated player may perform closer to 82. Prioritise these players in your starting eleven.
- **↗ (green, diagonal):** Slight boost. +1–2 to attributes. Reliable but not transformative.
- **→ (yellow, flat):** Neutral. The player performs at their listed attributes. Most of your squad will show this arrow for most matches.
- **↘ (orange, diagonal down):** Slight penalty. –1–2.
- **↓ (red, angled down):** Out of form. –3–5 to all attributes. A 78-rated player performs around 73–75. Do not start a player with a red arrow unless you have no alternative.

Form arrows are driven by recent match ratings, morale (see below), and a hidden consistency attribute. A player on a run of high ratings will sustain green arrows. A player who has been benched for three weeks will likely show orange or red. Play your squad — a match-fit reserve is more useful than a rusty starter.

Game Plan Selection: Choose the tactical preset that matches the opponent. Against a stronger side away from home, load a compact, counter-attacking tactic. Against a weaker side at home, load your possession tactic. The pre-match screen shows the opponent's expected formation — use it. If they are playing a 4-2-3-1 with a creative attacking midfielder, your defensive midfielder should have Tight Marking assigned to that player before kick-off.

In-Match: Reading the Game

The match screen shows two key pieces of live information:

Stamina Bar: Below each player name in the pause menu or formation screen, a bar shows remaining stamina. Full bar = 100%. A player drops below 60% stamina around the 60th minute (earlier if you press aggressively or the player is returning from injury). Below 50%, sprint speed, acceleration, and passing accuracy degrade noticeably. **The 60-minute mark and the 75-minute**

mark are the two critical substitution windows. At 60 minutes, your most active positions (full-backs, box-to-box midfielders, pressing forwards) will be at or near the threshold. At 75 minutes, stamina drops sharply for players who have been sprinting — the degradation accelerates in the final 15 minutes.

Substitution Timing:

- **60'** — The tactical window. Replace tired full-backs and midfielders. Substitutions now are about maintaining your game state. If you are winning, bring on a defensive midfielder for an attacker to see out the game. If you are losing, bring on fresh legs in wide positions to stretch the opponent.
- **75'** — The emergency window. Replace anyone below 50% stamina regardless of their rating. A 72-rated substitute with full stamina is more effective in the final 15 minutes than a tired 82-rated starter. The stamina penalty compounds — a player at 40% is moving at roughly three-quarters of their normal speed.
- **85'+** — The desperation window. Substitutions this late are for time-wasting (if winning) or throwing on an extra striker (if losing a knockout match). They rarely change the tactical shape of the game because there is not enough time for the substitutes to influence play.

You get three substitution windows per match (plus half-time, which does not count toward the limit). Batch your substitutions — make two at 60 minutes and the third at 75, rather than one at 60, one at 65, and one at 70, which wastes windows.

Morale

Morale is a hidden attribute that surfaces through form arrows and player responsiveness. It is driven by:

- **Recent results:** Winning raises morale across the squad. Losing drops it. A losing streak of 3+ matches cascades — poor morale produces poor performances, which produce more losses.
- **Playing time:** Regular starters maintain neutral or positive morale. Squad players need occasional starts to avoid morale decline. A player listed as “Squad Role: Rotation” who has not started a match in six weeks will show declining form arrows.
- **Team talks:** Pre-match and half-time team talks (selectable options ranging from “Expect a win” to “No pressure”) affect morale for that match. A team talk that is too demanding for a young squad can backfire — “Expect a win” before a tough away fixture may raise pressure and reduce performance rather than motivate.
- **Contract satisfaction:** A player who has requested a new contract and been ignored will show deteriorating morale regardless of results. Check the Squad screen for the “Unhappy” flag next to player names.

Managing low morale: There is no “reset morale” button. You break a morale spiral by winning. In the short term, drop out-of-form players to the bench (a neutral arrow from the bench does not harm you) and field anyone with a green or yellow arrow, even if their overall rating is slightly lower. A 75-rated player on an up arrow can outperform a 79-rated player on a down arrow for a single match.

Half-Time Adjustments

The half-time screen lets you change your game plan, make substitutions, and adjust individual instructions. Key adjustments to consider:

- **You are winning 1–0 but being dominated:** The scoreline is lying to you. Drop your attack/defence level from 3 to 2. Reduce pressing intensity. Consider bringing on a defensive midfielder. The opponent’s pressure will continue — if you do not adjust, the equaliser is a matter of time.
- **You are losing 0–1 but creating chances:** Change nothing about your shape. Increase attack/defence level from 3 to 4. Trigger more manual runs. The goal will come if you maintain the same approach at higher intensity.

- **You are losing 0–1 and creating nothing:** You have a tactical problem, not an effort problem. Switch to a different formation preset. If the opponent is sitting deep in a 4-4-2, switch to a 3-5-2 that overloads the midfield. If they are pressing high and your build-up is collapsing, switch to a formation with a dedicated deep-lying playmaker.

The half-time team talk options appear after you confirm your tactical changes. “Expect more” works for a squad with high team spirit; “Keep it up” maintains morale during a good performance; “No pressure” is the safe option when morale is fragile.

Weather & Pitch Conditions

Rain affects ball physics in FL26 — the ball skids on wet grass, making through-balls travel further and low-driven shots harder to handle. Adjust accordingly: shorter passing in the rain to maintain possession, more long shots (the keeper’s handling is reduced), and conservative slide tackles (wet pitch = longer slide, higher foul risk). The match preview screen shows weather before kick-off.

Manager Personas

Before you commit to a multi-season save, pick a persona. Each one imposes restrictions that turn Master League from a sandbox into a story. The rules are self-enforced — the game will not stop you from breaking them, but the save loses its tension the moment you do. Choose the one that makes you uncomfortable.

Difficulty baseline: Professional, 10-minute halves, normal game speed. These are dials, not dogma. Bump up if you are winning by February; drop down if you cannot score by November. The persona-specific settings below override this baseline where noted.

The Disgraced Legend

[They still sing his name in the Curva Sud. They also still spit it.]

Marco Vieri was a Ballon d'Or podium finisher at twenty-three. By twenty-seven, his career had detonated in a Monaco hotel room — an altercation with a teammate, a shattered orbital bone, and an eighteen-month ban that ended his top-flight career before it began. The punditry circuit kept him visible for a decade: the knowing smirk, the merciless analysis, the unspoken question of whether he could still do it. Every former player on the panel has an opinion. Vieri has decided to stop having opinions and start having results.

He takes over a relegation-zone Championship side in late autumn. The squad is demoralised, the defence leaks goals from set pieces, and the board's primary ambition is avoiding administration. Vieri does not care about any of this. He cares about whether a back-three can still function in modern football — because it is the only system he ever trusted as a player, and he will not abandon it now. The question is not whether he can manage. The question is whether anyone still wants to be managed by him.

- **Suggested teams:** Derby County, Portsmouth, Hull City
- **Formation:** Back-three mandatory — 3-5-2, 3-4-3, or 3-4-2-1. No four-at-the-back formations, ever.
- **Transfers:** No signings from the Premier League, LaLiga, Serie A, Bundesliga, Ligue 1, or Eredivisie for two full seasons. You are rebuilding reputation, not buying it.
- **Youth:** Promote two academy graduates to the first-team squad each season. They do not need to start every match, but they must appear in the match-day eighteen.
- **Budget:** No single transfer fee may exceed fifty percent of your available transfer budget. You spread resources, not bet the club on one name.
- **Match settings:** Professional, 10-minute halves. Increase to Superstar after promotion to the Premier League — you came back to face the best, not hide from them.
- **Narrative goal:** Premier League promotion within four seasons. A domestic cup (FA Cup or Carabao) before the end of season six. If Vieri lifts silverware at Wembley, the arc closes. If he does not, the pundits were right.

The Data Unicorn

[Lena Okonkwo has never kicked a ball professionally. She has, however, built three quantitative hedge funds, sold two of them, and retired at thirty-four.]

Okonkwo's introduction to football was an accident. She bought a mid-table second-division club on a whim — the kind of purchase that reads as a rounding error in her portfolio and an existential event in the club's accounts. Her original plan was to install a competent director

of football and check the quarterly reports. Instead, she fired the manager after watching six matches, concluded that the scouting department was operating on vibes, and had her former quant team install PostgreSQL in the analysis room. The players now receive expected-threat heatmaps with their post-match meals.

She does not care about tradition, pundit narratives, or the football men who have been doing it this way for thirty years. She cares about data that survives a significance test. Every transfer target is ranked by a proprietary model that weights match ratings, physical output, age curves, and wage efficiency. Every player below replacement level receives ten matches to prove the model wrong, then goes on the transfer list. The dressing room finds this terrifying. The league table is starting to find it persuasive.

- **Suggested teams:** A mid-table side in the 2. Bundesliga, LaLiga 2, or EFL Championship — enough budget to build infrastructure, not enough to buy your way out.
- **Formation:** 4-2-3-1 gegenpress (primary), 4-3-3 with inverted full-backs (possession variant), or 3-4-3 fluid (chaos variant). The model will tell you which performs best against each opponent.
- **Transfers:** Target only players whose average match rating over the last full season exceeds the league median for their position. No signings over age twenty-eight — the depreciation curve is real and it is steep.
- **Wages:** Your highest earner must not exceed twice the squad median wage. If your star striker earns €80k per week and your median is €25k, you have a problem the model will flag.
- **Scouting:** Build a stat-ranked shortlist at each window. Any player who drops below replacement level after ten competitive matches must be transfer-listed. Data does not negotiate.
- **Match settings:** Professional, 10-minute halves. Drop to Regular if you are losing matches faster than you can collect meaningful data points — the model needs a minimum sample size.
- **Narrative goal:** Achieve promotion to the top flight with a squad whose average age is under twenty-five. Prove that a spreadsheet can beat a dugout.

The Basque Purist

[Iker Etxebarria was born three hundred metres from San Mamés. His father laid the pitch. His grandfather watched Pichichi score.]

Four hundred and twelve matches for Athletic Bilbao. Never left the club, never wanted to. When the manager's job opened, Etxebarria was the obvious candidate — club legend, UEFA Pro Licence, fifteen years coaching La Cantera. He negotiated control of the academy as a condition of taking the job. The board thanked him for his service and appointed someone with a more cosmopolitan CV. The rejection did not wound his pride. It clarified his purpose.

He takes the philosophy on the road. Cantera — the belief that a club should field players it raised, or at least players from the region it represents — works at Athletic because the Basque Country is a footballing nation unto itself. Etxebarria intends to prove it works elsewhere. He arrives at a club with a functional academy and a strong regional identity, and he imposes the same constraints: sign only from the nation or the immediate geographic region, promote relentlessly from the youth ranks, and never stand in the way of a player who wants to leave. The philosophy is the point. The trophies, if they come, are evidence.

- **Suggested teams:** SC Freiburg (Baden identity, elite academy), Real Sociedad (Basque policy already exists — now enforce it ruthlessly), ACF Fiorentina (Tuscan roots, world-class youth setup)
- **Formation:** 4-2-3-1 or 4-4-2. Nothing exotic — the system serves the players, not the coach's vanity.

- **Transfers:** Sign only players from the club's home nation or immediate geographic region. For Freiburg: Germany, Austria, Switzerland, Alsace. For La Real: Basque Country, Navarre, La Rioja. For Fiorentina: Italy, with preference for Tuscany and surrounding regions. Accept every transfer request — a player who wants out is already gone. Honour-system rule.
- **Youth:** Develop three first-team-ready academy graduates within four seasons. "First-team-ready" means at least twenty competitive appearances, not five-minute cameos.
- **Squad:** Minimum three home-grown players in every match-day squad. Check the Player Registration screen — the HG icon is your compass.
- **Match settings:** Professional, 12-minute halves. Youth players need real minutes to develop, and longer halves give you time to blood them without panicking about the result.
- **Narrative goal:** Win a top-flight league title with a squad that is at least fifty percent academy graduates or regional signings. The percentage is the trophy.

The Journeyman

[Fifty-three years old. Fourteen clubs. Eight countries. Zero major trophies.]

Thomas Krause is the firefighter, the stopgap, the safe pair of hands who takes over in November when the board has lost patience and the dressing room has lost belief. He stabilises, he organises, he leaves before the credit arrives. His wife stopped asking which city years ago. His children track his career via Wikipedia — the entry is accurate but thin, a list of appointments and departures with no honours section. Krause does not have an honours section.

He has one cycle left. Seven seasons, give or take, before the body and the travel and the accumulated departures make the decision for him. He will take the lowest-ranked playable job available — not as a gimmick, but because that is where the phone rings. He will build nothing permanent, keep nothing he cannot carry in a single suitcase, and move on when the work is done. The career has been honourable and anonymous. The final act will determine whether it was also meaningful.

- **Suggested teams:** The lowest-ranked playable side in any league — the team you scroll past in the job search because the budget is zero and the squad is a collection of loan returnees. Pick the worst one.
- **Job movement:** Change clubs every two seasons. Accept the first reasonable offer that arrives — Krause does not get to be choosy. If no offer arrives by the end of the second season, resign and take the next available job at any level. Honour-system rule.
- **Transfers:** Free agents and loans only. No permanent transfer fees, ever. You are the man clubs call when they have no budget — act like it.
- **Squad:** A fresh start at every club. You cannot bring players from your previous team, no matter how much you developed them. That was their project; this is the next one.
- **Hard stop:** Age sixty equals seven seasons. PES Master League does not model manager aging, so this is an honour-system rule: after seven seasons, the career is over regardless of outcome. If Krause has not won a major trophy by then, the career is complete but unfulfilled. That is an ending too.
- **Match settings:** Top Player, 8-minute halves, fast game speed. Krause has been doing this for thirty years — he reads the game faster than you do. Increase to Superstar at the final club.
- **Narrative goal:** Win a top-flight league title before retirement. One. Just one.

Self-Imposed Rule Frameworks

Not every save needs a full persona. Sometimes you want to build your own manager and impose a lighter set of constraints. These frameworks slot into any Master League career. Stack them, mix them, or use one as a spine. All are honour-system — the game will not enforce them. You will know.

Transfer Realism

Sell before you buy above a self-set threshold — one out for every major incoming transfer. Honour release clauses honestly: if a buying club meets the clause, you accept and negotiate, no reloading. Free agents are for your squad, not for flipping — sign a free agent to play him, not to list him the next window for pure profit.

Scouting Realism

Only scout regions with credible real-world ties to your club. A mid-table Eredivisie side does not run a scouting network in Brazil and Argentina — build the network outward from your region. Global scouting unlocks only when your club reaches the Champions League group stage; until then, you find players the way real clubs do: domestically, then regionally, then selectively abroad.

Youth-First

Every match-day squad must include at least two academy graduates. The transfer budget exists to supplement your academy pipeline, not replace it — no signing a twenty-three-year-old for a position where an eighteen-year-old graduate needs minutes. If you must choose between a marquee signing and upgrading the youth facilities, upgrade the facilities.

Financial Fair Play

Wage expenditure must not exceed seventy percent of club revenue, checked at the end of each transfer window. No running an operating deficit across two consecutive windows — the board will not bail you out and neither will a reload. Budget discipline is the difference between a sustainable project and a liquidation event.

Sporting Director Mode

Delegate all transfer negotiations to the CPU. Set your scouting priorities, identify targets, add them to the shortlist — then let the sporting director handle bids, wages, and contract terms. You coach the players you are given, whether you would have signed them or not. This is the mode for managers who want to be judged on the pitch, not in the negotiation room — and it is the closest FL26 gets to simulating a real head coach's scope of authority.

